Strategic Plan

MENTORING

Hertfordshire Freemasons

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“We do not retain members by design; we build a culture that prepares and supports them — retention follows naturally.”

HERTFORDSHIRE FREEMASONS

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HERTFORDSHIRE FREEMASONS

Foreword

Retention is one of the most significant challenges facing Freemasonry in England today. This is not speculation; it is a reality recognised by the United Grand Lodge of England and reflected consistently in national research, the Members' Pathway, and the work of the Board of General Purposes.

While some losses are inevitable—through illness, age, relocation, or changing personal circumstances—too many are avoidable. They arise not from a lack of goodwill, but from men being poorly prepared, insufficiently supported, and inadequately looked after during their early years in Freemasonry and as they progress through the Lodge and into office.

If this is not addressed, the position will not improve. It will deteriorate.

UGLE's guidance is clear: completing the ceremonies is only the beginning. A member's long-term satisfaction, enjoyment, and commitment depend on how well he is supported, how clearly he understands what he has joined, and how valued he feels as an individual. Where that support is inconsistent, absent, or replaced by outdated attitudes, disengagement follows.

In some cases, retention is further undermined by poor practice. This includes self-promotion rather than encouragement of others, a reluctance to share knowledge, and behaviours that seek—intentionally or otherwise—to hold Brethren back. Examples include discouraging visiting until after the Third Degree, creating unnecessary mystique around aspects of Freemasonry that should be explained with care and clarity, and adopting a "sink or swim" approach to progression. Such practices run counter to both UGLE guidance and the fundamental principles of kindness, tolerance, and mutual support.

This Strategic Plan exists to help change that culture.

It is founded on several critical principles.

First, men must be properly prepared and supported throughout their entire Masonic journey—from interview and initiation, through progression and office, into the Chair, and well beyond it. Preparation and mentoring are not time-limited activities; they are continuous responsibilities.

Secondly, Freemasonry thrives on connection. Brethren who visit other Lodges, engage in Provincial meetings and events, participate in Light Blues and social activity, and build friendships across the Province are more confident, more informed, and more likely to remain committed. Isolation weakens engagement; connection strengthens it.

Thirdly, effective mentoring requires the early identification of disengagement or difficulty, followed by timely, compassionate intervention. UGLE's work consistently demonstrates that resignation is often preceded by warning signs. When those signs are recognised and addressed early, many losses can be prevented.

Above all, this Plan seeks to promote a positive Provincial culture in which mentoring is understood not as a title or a role held by a few, but as a shared responsibility. Every Freemason should regard

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himself as a mentor to someone. Every Brother should want others to succeed—both in Freemasonry and in life.

Freemasonry is a voluntary pursuit. Men give their time freely. The rewards it offers are personal rather than material: self-improvement, enduring friendships, mutual support in times of need, and the opportunity to serve others. It is not a job, it should never feel like a burden, and it must remain enjoyable.

Enjoyment will mean different things to different men, and a healthy Province recognises this by adapting to individual needs while upholding shared standards and values. This Strategic Plan is therefore not about targets or control, but about care, consistency, and culture—ensuring that Freemasonry in Hertfordshire is something men are proud to join, supported to enjoy, and inspired to remain part of over time. It does not seek retention as an end in itself; rather, it focuses on shaping a positive culture that prepares, supports, guides, and enlightens Brethren throughout their Masonic journey, with retention emerging naturally as the outcome of doing this well.

This Plan asks not 'How do we keep members?' but 'How do we make Freemasonry so rewarding that men never want to leave?

Wes Pierce

December 2025

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HERTFORDSHIRE FREEMASONS

1. Introduction to the Purpose of the Document

1.1 PURPOSE OF THIS STRATEGIC DOCUMENT

This document sets out the Strategic Plan for the Provincial Grand Mentor (PGM) of Hertfordshire, providing a clear framework for the development, delivery, and continuous improvement of mentoring across the Province.

Its purpose is to establish a coherent, consistent, and member-centred mentoring infrastructure that supports Lodges in nurturing enjoyable, meaningful, and sustainable Masonic membership. The strategy recognises that effective mentoring is not an isolated activity, but a fundamental enabler of member satisfaction, learning, engagement, and long-term commitment.

The plan is intended to be:

- A strategic reference for the Provincial Executive
- A practical guide for Lodge Mentors and mentoring teams
- A supporting framework that complements Lodge autonomy rather than replaces it

1.2 STRATEGIC CONTEXT

Freemasonry in England continues to operate in a changing social environment. Members' expectations, available time, learning preferences, and personal circumstances vary widely and evolve throughout their Masonic journey. Research and experience consistently demonstrate that members remain committed when they feel supported, valued, informed, and engaged, and are more likely to resign when these needs are unmet.

The United Grand Lodge of England's Members' Pathway places mentoring at the heart of:

- Supporting new members
- Sustaining engagement through learning and participation
- Identifying and responding early to dissatisfaction or disengagement
- Retaining members during periods of change, including relocation

This Strategic Plan aligns fully with those principles and builds upon them at a Provincial level, ensuring that Lodge Mentors are not working in isolation but are supported by a clear structure, shared standards, and accessible guidance .

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1.3 ROLE OF THE PROVINCIAL GRAND MENTOR

Within Hertfordshire, the Provincial Grand Mentor's core function is to prepare, guide, support and assist Lodge Mentors, promoting good practice and helping ensure mentoring is delivered consistently and effectively across all Lodges.

The Provincial Grand Mentor:

- Acts as the custodian of mentoring standards and quality
- Supports Lodge Mentors through training, guidance, and coaching
- Monitors mentoring effectiveness at a Provincial level
- Works collaboratively with other Provincial Officers, particularly those responsible for membership and learning and development
- Provides insight to the Provincial Executive on mentoring health, risks, and opportunities

Importantly, the Provincial Grand Mentor does not replace the Lodge Mentor's role, nor interfere with Lodge governance. Instead, the role exists to enable Lodges to succeed in mentoring their members well.

1.4 GUIDING PRINCIPLES

This Strategic Plan is underpinned by the following guiding principles:

- **Member-centred**
  The needs, circumstances, and aspirations of the individual member must always remain central to the mentoring process.
- **Consistency with flexibility**
  While standards and good practice should be consistent across the Province, their application must remain flexible to suit individual Lodges and members.
- **Lifelong learning journey**
  Mentoring extends well beyond initiation and early degrees, supporting members throughout their Masonic life, including periods of progression, transition, and change.
- **Early intervention and prevention**
  Effective mentoring identifies emerging issues early and addresses them before dissatisfaction becomes disengagement or resignation.
- **Enjoyment and satisfaction**
  Members who enjoy Freemasonry, feel supported, and derive personal value from it are far more likely to remain committed over the long term.

These principles reflect both Provincial priorities and established UGLE guidance on mentoring, learning, and retention .

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1.5 SCOPE OF THE STRATEGIC PLAN

This document focuses on strategy rather than operational instruction. It defines:

- Strategic objectives for the Provincial Grand Mentor
- The supporting activities required to achieve those objectives
- The interfaces between mentoring, learning, membership, and retention
- The mechanisms for oversight, reporting, and continuous improvement

Detailed guidance, role descriptions, training materials, and Lodge-level tools will be developed separately and referenced where appropriate.

This plan does not prescribe specific Lodge-level processes or replace existing Lodge governance structures. It provides a Provincial framework within which Lodges maintain their autonomy while ensuring consistency of quality.

1.6 INTENDED AUDIENCE

This Strategic Plan is intended for:

- The Provincial Executive and relevant Provincial Officers
- Lodge Mentors and Lodge Membership Teams
- Those involved in mentoring, learning, and member support at Lodge and Provincial level

It is not intended as a manual for candidates or members, but as a framework to support those who support them.

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2. Executive Summary

This Strategic Plan sets out the framework through which the Provincial Grand Mentor of Hertfordshire will provide leadership, assurance, and support for mentoring across the Province. Its central purpose is to ensure that mentoring is effective, consistent, and member-centred, thereby maximising enjoyment, learning, satisfaction, and long-term commitment to Freemasonry.

The strategy recognises that mentoring is not an isolated activity, nor confined to new members alone. Instead, it is a continuous process that supports members throughout their Masonic journey and plays a vital role in retention, engagement, and Lodge sustainability.

2.1 Strategic Intent

The overarching intent of this plan is to establish a strong Provincial mentoring infrastructure that supports Lodge autonomy while ensuring consistency of good practice. The Provincial Grand Mentor acts as a strategic enabler and quality assurer, supporting Lodge Mentors rather than directing or managing Lodge activity.

The plan aligns fully with UGLE's Members' Pathway, reinforcing the principle that members remain committed when they feel welcomed, supported, informed, and valued.

2.2 The Four Strategic Objectives

The strategy is delivered through four interlinked objectives:

- **Strategic Oversight, Collaboration and Reporting**
  This objective will establish clear governance, collaboration, and reporting arrangements to ensure mentoring is aligned with Provincial priorities, supported by appropriate oversight, and subject to continuous improvement.
- **Support and Development for Lodge Mentors**
  This objective will ensures Lodge Mentors are clear about their role, supported through training and guidance, encouraged to serve with continuity, and connected to a Provincial community of practice.
- **Promoting Comprehensive Member Learning and Support**
  This objective will embed a balanced approach to learning that combines structured guided learning with personalised, continued mentoring, protecting members from undue pressure and supporting enjoyment at every stage.
- **Retention and Migration Management**
  This objective will position mentoring as a key contributor to retention, supporting early identification of disengagement, constructive handling of resignation, and effective management of member migration.

Together, these objectives form a coherent framework that moves from governance, to capability, to member experience, and finally to retention and sustainability.

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What Success Looks Like

In the short term (Year 1):

- Lodge Mentors report feeling equipped and supported
- Clear referral pathways are understood and used
- Provincial oversight mechanisms are established

In the medium term (Years 2-3):

- Members report improved satisfaction in feedback surveys
- Early warning signs are identified and addressed more quickly
- Mentoring consistency improves across the Province

In the long term (Years 3-5):

- Measurable improvement in retention rates, particularly in years 1-5 of membership
- Fewer resignations due to preventable causes
- Successful migration outcomes for relocating members

2.3 Conclusion

This Strategic Plan positions mentoring as a core enabler of a healthy, sustainable Province, not an administrative burden or short-term initiative. It provides clarity of purpose, alignment with national guidance, and a practical framework for delivery, while respecting the individuality and autonomy of Hertfordshire's Lodges.

Through collaboration, consistency, and a clear focus on the member experience, the Provincial Grand Mentor will help ensure that Freemasonry in Hertfordshire continues to be enjoyable, relevant, and enduring.

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3. Vision, Aims and Success Measures

"Effective mentoring isn't accidental—it's strategic, consistent, and member-centred"

3.1 VISION

The vision of the Provincial Grand Mentor for Hertfordshire is to ensure that every member, in every Lodge, experiences Freemasonry as welcoming, supportive, engaging, and personally rewarding, supported by mentoring that is consistent in quality, responsive to individual needs, and aligned with the values and expectations of English Freemasonry.

Through strong Provincial leadership and effective Lodge-level delivery, mentoring will:

- Enhance enjoyment and satisfaction
- Support learning and understanding
- Encourage appropriate participation and progression
- Strengthen commitment and retention

This vision reflects the principle that mentoring is not an optional addition to Lodge life, but a core enabler of a healthy, sustainable Province, as recognised within UGLE's Members' Pathway .

3.2 STRATEGIC AIMS

To realise this vision, the Provincial Grand Mentor Strategic Plan is built around the following core aims.

3.2.1 Establish a Strong Provincial Mentoring Infrastructure

To create and maintain a clear Provincial framework that:

- Defines good mentoring practice
- Supports Lodge Mentors in their coordinating role
- Provides consistency, continuity, and quality assurance across the Province

This includes ensuring that Lodge Mentors are trained, supported, and connected, and that mentoring activity aligns with wider Provincial membership and learning objectives .

3.2.2 Support Lodge Mentors to Be Effective and Confident

To equip Lodge Mentors with:

- Clear role definition and expectations
- Access to accurate, up-to-date guidance and resources
- Opportunities for training, peer support, and coaching

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Recognising that the Lodge Mentor is a co-ordinator rather than a universal mentor, the strategy aims to ensure they are supported to manage mentoring processes effectively, including the selection and support of Personal Mentors .

3.2.3 Promote Member-Centred Mentoring Throughout the Masonic Journey

To embed a mentoring culture that places the individual member at the centre, responding to their needs for:

- Information and understanding
- Personal contact and support
- One-to-one guidance appropriate to their stage of membership

This applies not only to candidates and new members, but throughout a member's Masonic life, including progression, office, learning ritual, Royal Arch consideration, and periods of change or difficulty .

3.2.4 Strengthen Learning, Understanding, and Enjoyment

To ensure mentoring supports both:

- **Guided Learning** – what Freemasonry expects members to understand in order to participate fully
- **Personal Learning** – what individual members wish to explore to satisfy curiosity and deepen engagement

The aim is to reduce confusion, prevent misinformation, and support lifelong learning using reliable sources such as Solomon and approved Provincial materials, thereby increasing satisfaction and confidence .

3.2.5 Improve Retention Through Early Support and Intervention

To reduce avoidable losses by:

- Encouraging early identification of disengagement or dissatisfaction
- Supporting Lodges in addressing issues compassionately and constructively
- Providing clear referral routes to Provincial support when Lodge-level resolution is insufficient

This includes close alignment with retrieval, resignation, and migration processes, recognising that many resignations are preventable when mentoring is effective and timely .

3.3 Success Measures

The success of this Strategic Plan will be assessed through a combination of quantitative indicators and qualitative evidence, recognising that mentoring effectiveness cannot be measured by numbers alone.

3.3.1 Provincial-Level Indicators

Success at a Provincial level will be measured through:

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QUANTITATIVE INDICATORS:

- Retention Rate: Percentage of members remaining active 5 years post-initiation
  - Baseline (2025): To be established in Year 1
  - Target (2030): 15% improvement over baseline
- Early Resignation: Resignations within first 3 years of membership
  - Baseline (2025): To be established in Year 1
  - Target (2028): 25% reduction from baseline
- Lodge Mentor Coverage: Percentage of Lodges with appointed, trained Lodge Mentors
  - Baseline (2025): To be established in Year 1
  - Target (2026): 100% coverage
- Migration Success: Percentage of relocating members successfully transferred
  - Baseline (2025): To be established in Year 1
  - Target (2027): 75% successful transfers

QUALITATIVE INDICATORS:

- Lodge Mentor feedback surveys (annual)
- Member satisfaction surveys (biennial)
- Case studies of successful interventions
- Examples of good practice shared across Province

3.3.2 Lodge-Level Indicators

At Lodge level, indicators of effective mentoring may include:

- Positive feedback from members on feeling welcomed, supported, and informed
- Healthy patterns of attendance and participation
- Appropriate, unpressured progression through degrees and offices
- Evidence of continued mentoring beyond early membership
- Reduced incidence of unresolved dissatisfaction or disengagement

These indicators align with UGLE guidance that satisfied, engaged members are more likely to remain committed and contribute positively to Lodge life .

3.3.3 Qualitative Measures

Equally important will be:

- Feedback from Lodge Mentors on the clarity and usefulness of Provincial support
- Observations from Lodge visits and mentoring reviews
- Case studies demonstrating successful intervention, retrieval, or migration
- Evidence of improved confidence and consistency among mentoring teams

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Such qualitative insight will inform continuous improvement and refinement of Provincial mentoring support.

3.4 Review and Continuous Improvement

This Strategic Plan is intended to be a living document. Regular review will ensure that:

- Objectives remain aligned with Provincial priorities and UGLE guidance
- Emerging challenges and opportunities are addressed
- Good practice is identified, shared, and embedded across the Province

The Provincial Grand Mentor will use these reviews to recommend adjustments, additional initiatives, or refreshed priorities as required.

This Strategic Plan will be reviewed through:

ANNUAL REVIEW:

- Conducted by Provincial Grand Mentor with Provincial Executive
- Assessment of progress against Action Plan
- Identification of emerging challenges
- Adjustment of priorities as needed

MID-TERM REVIEW (Year 3):

- Comprehensive evaluation of all four strategic objectives
- Consultation with Lodge Mentors and members
- Revision of success measures if needed
- Updated Action Plan for remaining period

FULL REVIEW (Year 5):

- Complete strategic assessment
- Stakeholder consultation
- Development of next 5-year strategy
- Celebration of achievements and learning from challenges

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4. Strategic Objective One

STRATEGIC OVERSIGHT, COLLABORATION AND REPORTING

4.1 Purpose of this Objective

This strategic objective establishes the governance, oversight, and collaborative arrangements through which mentoring is led, supported, and reviewed across the Province of Hertfordshire.

Its purpose is to ensure that mentoring activity:

- Is strategically aligned with Provincial priorities
- Is consistent in quality, while remaining flexible at Lodge level
- Benefits from collaboration rather than isolation
- Is subject to proportionate oversight and meaningful reporting
- Supports continuous improvement, not compliance for its own sake

This objective positions the Provincial Grand Mentor as the strategic enabler and quality assurer of mentoring, rather than as an inspector or manager of Lodge activity.

4.2 Strategic Leadership and Provincial Alignment

The Provincial Grand Mentor will provide clear strategic leadership for mentoring across Hertfordshire, ensuring that mentoring activity aligns with:

- The Province's wider membership, learning, and retention strategy
- UGLE's Members' Pathway principles
- Agreed Provincial priorities and emerging needs

This will be achieved through close collaboration with key Provincial Officers, particularly those responsible for:

- Membership development
- Learning and development
- Wider care and support for masons (Almoner)

The aim is to ensure that Lodges receive joined-up guidance, avoiding duplication, mixed messages, or gaps in support, and reinforcing that mentoring is integral to the Province's overall approach to member care and development.

4.3 Collaboration with Provincial and Lodge Officers

Effective mentoring does not operate in isolation. This strategy therefore emphasises structured collaboration, both at Provincial and Lodge level.

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At Provincial Level

The Provincial Grand Mentor will:

- Work closely with the Provincial Grand Membership Officer to align mentoring with recruitment, retention, retrieval, and migration activity
- Contribute mentoring insight to Provincial discussions on Lodge health, sustainability, and development
- Support the Provincial Executive with informed, evidence-based advice on mentoring-related risks and opportunities

This collaborative approach ensures that mentoring intelligence informs Provincial decision-making in a timely and constructive manner.

At Lodge Level

The Provincial Grand Mentor will support Lodges by:

- Reinforcing the distinct but complementary roles of Lodge Mentors, Membership Officers, Almoners, and other support officers
- Encouraging clear local arrangements for communication, referral, and escalation
- Promoting mentoring as a shared Lodge responsibility, coordinated by the Lodge Mentor but owned collectively

At all times, Lodge autonomy is respected, with Provincial involvement focused on support, guidance, and enabling success.

4.4 Oversight of Mentoring Effectiveness

Provincial oversight of mentoring is intended to be light-touch, proportionate, and purposeful.

The Provincial Grand Mentor will monitor mentoring effectiveness across the Province by:

- Maintaining an overview of Lodge Mentor appointments and continuity
- Identifying patterns, themes, and emerging risks from Lodge feedback
- Using qualitative insight from Lodge visits, conversations, and mentoring events
- Reviewing relevant trends in retention, resignation, and migration data

This oversight is not about assessing individual mentors, but about understanding how well mentoring systems are functioning and where additional support may be required.

4.5 Reporting and Accountability

Clear reporting arrangements ensure accountability while supporting trust and transparency.

The Provincial Grand Mentor will:

- Provide regular reports to the Provincial Executive (or agreed committee), summarising:
  - Overall mentoring health and engagement
  - Key themes and observations
  - Risks, challenges, and examples of good practice

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  - Recommended actions or areas for focus
- Contribute mentoring insight to broader Provincial reviews of Lodge health and sustainability
- Ensure that reporting focuses on learning and improvement, not criticism

Where appropriate, anonymised feedback and thematic findings may be shared with Lodges to support reflection and improvement without attributing blame.

4.6 Use of Data and Feedback

The Provincial Grand Mentor recognizes that effective oversight requires reliable data. During Year 1, priority will be given to:

- Establishing baseline measurements for key metrics
- Developing simple data collection mechanisms for Lodges
- Implementing a Provincial dashboard for tracking trends
- Creating feedback loops that inform continuous improvement

Quantitative data (such as attendance trends, retention figures, or migration activity) will be used carefully and contextually, recognizing that numbers alone never tell the full story.

4.7 Continuous Improvement and Targeted Support

Where trends indicate concern—such as multiple resignations, declining engagement, or mentoring difficulties—the Provincial Grand Mentor will:

- Encourage Lodges to undertake reflective reviews
- Offer targeted support, guidance, or coaching
- Facilitate access to Provincial resources or peer support
- Work collaboratively with other Provincial Officers to develop focused responses

This ensures that intervention is timely, proportionate, and supportive, increasing the likelihood of successful outcomes for both members and Lodges.

4.8 Outcome of Strategic Objective One

When this objective is delivered effectively:

- Mentoring is strategically aligned and well governed
- Lodge Mentors feel supported rather than scrutinised
- The Province has clear visibility of mentoring health
- Risks are identified early and addressed constructively
- Continuous improvement becomes embedded practice

This foundation enables the successful delivery of the subsequent strategic objectives focused on Lodge Mentor support, member learning, and retention.

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5. Strategic Objective Two

SUPPORT AND DEVELOPMENT FOR LODGE MENTORS

5.1 Purpose of this Objective

This strategic objective focuses on ensuring that Lodge Mentors are properly supported, equipped, and confident to fulfil their coordinating role effectively within their Lodges.

The Lodge Mentor is pivotal to the success of mentoring. When the role is clearly understood, well supported, and sustained over time, mentoring is more consistent, responsive, and impactful. Conversely, where Lodge Mentors are unclear, isolated, or under-supported, mentoring activity often becomes fragmented, inconsistent, or dependent on individuals rather than systems.

The purpose of this objective is therefore to establish a Provincial support framework that enables Lodge Mentors to succeed, while respecting Lodge autonomy and recognising that all involved are volunteers.

5.2 The Role of the Lodge Mentor – Strategic Emphasis

This strategy reinforces the established principle that the Lodge Mentor is:

- A co-ordinator of the mentoring process
- Not the mentor to every new or existing member
- Responsible for oversight, matching, support, and continuity
- A key link between the Lodge and the Province on mentoring matters

The Provincial Grand Mentor will continue to promote clarity of role, ensuring that:

- Expectations of Lodge Mentors are realistic and achievable
- Lodge Mentors are not overburdened or expected to "do everything"
- The distinction between Lodge Mentor and Personal Mentor is clearly understood and maintained

Clear role understanding is foundational to effective mentoring delivery.

5.3 Training and Development for Lodge Mentors

The Provincial Grand Mentor will establish and maintain a structured programme of training and development for Lodge Mentors.

This will include, as appropriate:

- Initial briefing or induction for newly appointed Lodge Mentors
- Periodic training sessions focused on good practice, emerging issues, and practical problem-solving
- Opportunities to share experience, challenges, and solutions with peers

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- Targeted one-to-one support or coaching where required
- Monthly mentoring call
- A Mentoring & Membership Past Masters' Lodge, meeting twice annually, providing a formal mechanism for communication, alignment, and recognition in support of mentoring, membership development, and educational delivery
- Delivery of the explanation of the mentors Jewel to persons appointed to the role of mentor

Training will be:

- Practical rather than theoretical
- Grounded in real Lodge experience
- Aligned with UGLE guidance and the Members' Pathway
- Designed to build confidence, not impose bureaucracy

The emphasis will be on helping Lodge Mentors feel supported, capable, and connected, rather than assessed.

5.4 Provision of Guidance and Resources

The Provincial Grand Mentor will be responsible for the development, maintenance, and dissemination of Provincial mentoring guidance for Lodge Mentors.

This may include:

- Role descriptions and expectations
- Checklists and prompts for mentoring coordination
- Mentoring Guiding Principles of Prepare, Guide, Support and Enlighten, including guides across the positions
- Signposting to authoritative resources, including Solomon

All guidance will aim to be:

- Clear, concise, and accessible
- Accurate and up to date
- Consistent with UGLE policy and terminology
- Supportive rather than prescriptive

This approach helps prevent confusion, misinformation, and the perpetuation of outdated practices or local myths.

5.5 Encouraging Consistency and Continuity

Consistency over time is critical to effective mentoring.

The Provincial Grand Mentor will therefore:

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- Encourage Lodges to appoint Lodge Mentors who are willing and able to serve for a sustained period, typically three to five years
- Promote orderly handover arrangements when Lodge Mentors change
- Support continuity of mentoring records, processes, and relationships

To support continuity, Lodge Mentors are encouraged to:

- Maintain simple records of mentoring arrangements and member progress
- Document key contacts and referral pathways
- Brief successor on ongoing situations (with appropriate confidentiality)
- Consider developing a "shadow" Lodge Mentor in larger Lodges
- Attend handover meeting when stepping down

This approach:

- Reduces the need to repeatedly “restart” mentoring systems
- Builds confidence and experience within the role
- Enhances trust between Lodge Mentors and the Province

While respecting the Master’s prerogative in appointments, the strategy encourages Lodges to view the Lodge Mentor role as a medium-term stewardship, not an annual rotation.

5.6 Peer Support and Community of Practice

Recognising that Lodge Mentors benefit greatly from shared experience, the Provincial Grand Mentor will foster a Provincial community of practice for Lodge Mentors.

This may include:

- Regular meetings (in person or online)
- Themed discussions around common challenges
- Sharing examples of effective practice
- Informal networking and mutual support

Such peer engagement:

- Reduces isolation
- Encourages confidence and consistency
- Builds shared understanding across the Province
- Reinforces that Lodge Mentors are part of a wider Provincial team

5.7 Support for Managing Challenges and Escalation

Lodge Mentors will inevitably encounter situations that are:

- Sensitive
- Complex
- Beyond what can reasonably be resolved within the Lodge alone

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The Provincial Grand Mentor will ensure Lodge Mentors:

- Understand when and how to seek Provincial support
- Feel confident escalating issues without fear of criticism
- Receive timely advice, guidance, or referral as appropriate

This reinforces that asking for help is a strength, and that the Province exists to support Lodges, particularly where mentoring, retention, or member welfare may be at risk.

5.8 Outcome of Strategic Objective Two

When this objective is delivered effectively:

- Lodge Mentors are clear about their role and boundaries
- Lodge Mentors feel supported, trained, and connected
- Mentoring coordination becomes more consistent across Lodges
- Good practice is shared and sustained
- The quality of mentoring improves without increasing burden

This objective provides the capability and confidence required to deliver the subsequent strategic objectives focused on member learning, support, and retention.

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6. Strategic Objective Three

PROMOTING COMPREHENSIVE MEMBER LEARNING AND SUPPORT

6.1 Purpose of this Objective

This strategic objective ensures that every member receives the learning and support they need to understand, enjoy, and remain committed to Freemasonry, in a manner appropriate to their stage of membership, personal circumstances, and individual interests.

It recognises that:

- Learning and mentoring are closely related but distinct
- Members' needs evolve throughout their Masonic journey
- Satisfaction, confidence, and enjoyment are strongly linked to understanding
- Poorly supported learning is a common contributor to disengagement and resignation

The objective therefore seeks to establish a balanced, structured, and member-centred approach that combines clear learning pathways with personalised mentoring support.

6.2 Member-Centred Approach to Learning and Support

At the heart of this strategy is the principle that the member remains central to all mentoring and learning activity.

The Provincial Grand Mentor will promote the understanding that:

- Support should be driven by the member's needs, not by institutional convenience
- Pace of learning and progression must suit the individual
- Different members will engage in different ways and to different extents
- Value and contribution are not measured solely by rank, office, or ritual ability

Lodge Mentors will be encouraged to work with Personal Mentors to ensure that members feel:

- Listened to
- Supported without pressure
- Confident to ask questions
- Valued regardless of their chosen level of involvement

6.3 Balancing Guided Learning and Personal Learning

This strategy reinforces the importance of maintaining a clear distinction and healthy balance between:

Guided Learning

What Freemasonry recommends members to learn in order to:

- Participate more confidently in Lodge life

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- Understand degrees, structure, and protocols
- Progress appropriately when they choose to do so

Guided learning should be:

- Planned and structured
- Accurate and up to date
- Delivered by those suitably experienced
- Reinforced through mentoring support

Personal Learning (Continued Mentoring)

What the individual member wishes to learn to:

- Satisfy curiosity
- Deepen understanding
- Explore interests within Freemasonry
- Gain personal fulfilment

Personal learning is:

- Ongoing throughout membership
- Led by the member's interests
- Supported primarily through one-to-one mentoring
- A key contributor to long-term satisfaction and retention

The Provincial Grand Mentor will promote understanding that both forms of learning are necessary, and that neglecting either risks dissatisfaction.

6.4 Supporting Learning at Different Stages of the Masonic Journey

The strategy recognises that learning and support requirements vary significantly across a member's journey.

Accordingly, Lodge Mentors will be encouraged to ensure appropriate support for:

- Candidates and new members adjusting to unfamiliar experiences
- Entered Apprentices and Fellow Crafts preparing for progression
- Newly Raised Master Masons consolidating understanding
- Members entering or leaving progressive office
- Past Masters and experienced members taking on new responsibilities
- Members experiencing changes in circumstances, availability, or confidence

This reinforces that mentoring and learning are not time-limited activities, but evolve alongside the member.

6.5 Use of Reliable Learning Resources

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To support accurate and consistent learning, the Provincial Grand Mentor will encourage Lodges and mentors to make appropriate use of authoritative resources, including:

- Solomon, UGLE's online learning platform
- Approved Provincial guidance and materials
- Lodge history and established local practice, where accurate and appropriate

Lodge Mentors will be encouraged to:

- Signpost members to reliable sources
- Discourage speculation, outdated material, or unverified online content
- Ensure that learning is appropriate to the member's degree and experience

This approach helps prevent confusion, myth-building, and disengagement caused by misinformation.

The Provincial Grand Mentor recognizes that while Solomon is an excellent resource, it may not suit all learning styles or all members' digital confidence.

Lodge Mentors are encouraged to:

- Support members in accessing and navigating Solomon
- Provide alternative resources where digital access is challenging
- Balance online learning with face-to-face mentoring conversations
- Use printed materials from Solomon where appropriate
- Never make technology a barrier to learning

6.6 Protecting Members from Undue Pressure

An essential component of effective mentoring and support is protection from inappropriate pressure.

The Provincial Grand Mentor will reinforce the responsibility of Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors to:

- Guard against pressure to accept office, deliver ritual, or progress prematurely
- Encourage honest conversations about readiness, availability, and confidence
- Respect a member's choice to contribute in non-traditional or non-progressive ways
- Support members who wish to slow down or pause their involvement

This principle directly supports member wellbeing, enjoyment, and long-term commitment.

6.7 Guidance on Progression and the Royal Arch

The Royal Arch is described by UGLE as "the completion of Pure Antient Masonry."

While progression to the Royal Arch is a natural continuation for Master Masons, the emphasis in mentoring should be on:

TIMING rather than inevitability:

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- Ensuring sufficient time in the Craft to consolidate understanding
- Waiting until the member has expressed interest or asked questions
- Confirming the member has capacity for additional commitment
- Protecting against rushing or pressure

INFORMATION rather than recruitment:

- Explaining what the Royal Arch is and its place in Pure Antient Masonry
- Describing what to expect from Royal Arch membership
- Being honest about additional time and financial commitments
- Making clear that the Craft is complete and valuable in itself

The Provincial Grand Mentor will provide Lodge Mentors with balanced guidance on Royal Arch conversations, emphasizing member readiness over Lodge or Chapter recruitment targets.

6.8 Monitoring Impact on Member Satisfaction and Engagement

The Provincial Grand Mentor will encourage Lodges to:

- Reflect on how well learning and mentoring needs are being met
- Observe patterns in attendance, participation, and confidence
- Recognise early signs of frustration or disengagement linked to learning gaps

This insight will feed into Provincial oversight, helping identify where:

- Additional guidance is required
- Good practice can be shared
- Targeted support may prevent disengagement

6.9 Outcome of Strategic Objective Three

When this objective is delivered effectively:

- Members understand Freemasonry better and enjoy it more
- Learning is structured, accurate, and accessible
- Personal curiosity is encouraged rather than suppressed
- Members feel supported without being pressured
- Satisfaction and confidence increase across all stages of membership

This objective directly underpins retention by ensuring that members continue to find value in their Masonic experience as their needs evolve.

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7. Strategic Objective Four

RETENTION AND MIGRATION MANAGEMENT

7.1 Purpose of this Objective

This strategic objective focuses on retaining members within Freemasonry by ensuring that those who experience difficulty, dissatisfaction, or change in circumstances are identified early, supported appropriately, and offered constructive pathways to remain engaged.

It recognises that:

- Most resignations are preceded by warning signs
- Many resignations are avoidable
- Change of circumstances does not need to result in loss from the Craft
- Effective mentoring plays a central role in both prevention and recovery

The objective positions the Provincial Grand Mentor as a key contributor to Provincial retention efforts, working collaboratively with Lodges and other Provincial officers to retain members wherever possible.

7.2 Retention as a Mentoring Outcome

Retention is not treated as a numerical target, but as the natural outcome of members who feel supported, valued, and satisfied.

The Provincial Grand Mentor will promote the understanding that:

- Enjoyment, learning, and belonging are the primary drivers of retention
- Retention begins long before a resignation is considered
- Mentoring is a preventive activity as much as a supportive one

Lodge Mentors and Personal Mentors are therefore encouraged to see retention as:

- Everyone's responsibility
- Embedded in everyday mentoring conversations
- Achieved through listening, empathy, and timely support

7.3 Early Identification of Disengagement and Risk

A key element of effective retention is the early recognition of warning signs.

The Provincial Grand Mentor will support Lodges to:

- Recognise changes in attendance or participation patterns
- Be alert to reduced enthusiasm, reluctance to engage, or withdrawal
- Understand that disengagement often signals unmet needs rather than lack of interest

Lodge Mentors will be encouraged to work collaboratively with:

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- Lodge Almoners
- Lodge Membership Officers
- Personal Mentors
- Worshipful Masters and Wardens

The emphasis is on early, compassionate enquiry, not confrontation or pressure.

WARNING SIGNS TO RECOGNISE:

ATTENDANCE PATTERNS:

- Missed 2+ consecutive meetings without explanation
- Arrival late/leaving early becoming habitual
- Attendance only at installations or social events
- Stopping visiting other Lodges

PARTICIPATION CHANGES:

- Reluctance to accept or prepare for work
- Reduced engagement in Lodge conversations
- Minimal participation in social activities
- Absence from rehearsals when in office

COMMUNICATION INDICATORS:

- Not responding to Lodge or Personal Mentor contact
- Expressing frustration or disappointment
- Mentioning financial or time pressures repeatedly
- Comparing unfavourably with expectations or other organizations

EARLY INTERVENTION PROCESS:

Step 1: Personal Mentor makes friendly, informal contact

Step 2: Lodge Mentor becomes involved if concern continues

Step 3: Worshipful Master or other appropriate officer has conversation

Step 4: Referral to Provincial support if needed

The emphasis throughout should be on compassionate inquiry, not interrogation. The question is: "How can we help?" not "Why aren't you attending?"

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7.4 Referral Pathways and Provincial Support

Not all situations can or should be resolved at Lodge level.

This strategy establishes the principle that:

- Lodges should feel confident referring matters to the Province when appropriate
- Escalation is a sign of responsible mentoring, not failure
- Provincial involvement should be supportive, proportionate, and discreet

The Provincial Grand Mentor will help ensure that:

- Clear referral pathways exist
- Lodge Mentors understand when and how to seek support
- Appropriate Provincial officers are involved based on the nature of the issue
- Confidentiality and dignity are always respected

This approach increases the likelihood of successful outcomes while protecting relationships within Lodges.

7.5 Managing Resignation and Retrieval Constructively

When a member indicates an intention to resign, the strategy encourages a measured and respectful response.

The Provincial Grand Mentor will promote good practice that:

- Ensures the Lodge seeks to understand the underlying reasons
- Avoids defensive or dismissive responses
- Offers the member an opportunity to reconsider where appropriate
- Explores alternative solutions, including reduced involvement or Lodge transfer

Where resignation proceeds, the process should:

- Preserve goodwill
- Maintain future pathways for re-engagement
- Reinforce that the individual remains valued as a Freemason

This approach supports both immediate retention opportunities and longer-term retrieval.

7.6 Migration as a Retention Opportunity

Relocation is recognised as a significant retention risk, but also a clear opportunity to retain members through effective migration management.

The Provincial Grand Mentor will:

- Support the implementation and operation of the agreed Member Migration Process
- Encourage early identification of members planning to relocate
- Promote proactive engagement before resignation is considered

The objective of migration management is to:

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- Enable continuity of membership
- Minimise disruption to the member's Masonic journey
- Ensure the member feels welcomed and supported in their new locality

Migration is treated as a continuation of mentoring, not an administrative exercise.

7.7 Supporting Members Through Change

Members may experience periods where:

- Attendance reduces
- Capacity to participate fluctuates
- Confidence or motivation is affected

The Provincial Grand Mentor will reinforce the importance of mentoring that:

- Acknowledges life changes without judgement
- Encourages members to remain connected at a level that suits them
- Values continued membership even where participation is limited

This approach reduces unnecessary resignations driven by misplaced perceptions of obligation or guilt.

7.8 Monitoring Retention and Migration Trends

The Provincial Grand Mentor will work with relevant Provincial officers to:

- Review trends in resignation, retrieval, and migration
- Identify recurring themes or systemic issues
- Use insight to inform Provincial initiatives and guidance

Where patterns suggest wider challenges, the Provincial Grand Mentor may:

- Recommend targeted support for affected Lodges
- Encourage reflective reviews
- Facilitate access to additional resources or peer support

The focus remains on learning and improvement, not attribution of blame.

7.9 Outcome of Strategic Objective Four

When this objective is delivered effectively:

- Members feel supported during difficult or transitional periods
- Warning signs are identified and addressed earlier
- Fewer members are lost through preventable resignation
- Migration is managed smoothly and positively
- The Province retains experienced, committed Freemasons who continue to contribute over time

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This objective completes the strategic framework by ensuring that mentoring supports members not only as they join and develop, but as their circumstances change.

7.10 Strategic Plan Summary

Together, the four strategic objectives provide a coherent framework in which the Provincial Grand Mentor:

- Provides strategic oversight and assurance
- Enables and supports Lodge Mentors
- Promotes meaningful learning and support
- Contributes directly to retention and sustainability

The success of this strategy rests on collaboration, trust, and shared commitment to delivering a positive and enduring Masonic experience for every member.

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HERTFORDSHIRE FREEMASONS

Strategic Action Plan (Tactical Implementation)

This Action Plan supports delivery of the Provincial Grand Mentor Strategic Plan and is intended as a practical working tool for the Provincial Grand Mentor. It should be reviewed annually and updated as required.

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE ONE – STRATEGIC OVERSIGHT, COLLABORATION AND REPORTING

Ref	Action	Purpose / Outcome	Success Measures	Status
I.1	Establish regular liaison with Provincial Grand Membership Officer	Ensure alignment between mentoring, membership, retention and migration activity	Evidence of coordinated approach; reduced duplication	
I.2	Define mentoring reporting route to Provincial Executive	Provide clarity on accountability and assurance	Agreed reporting structure in place	
I.3	Produce annual mentoring overview report	Provide visibility of mentoring health and trends	Report received and discussed	
I.4	Develop mechanism for anonymised feedback from Lodges	Identify themes, risks and good practice	Regular qualitative insight available	
I.5	Identify Lodges requiring targeted mentoring support	Enable early, supportive intervention	Issues addressed earlier; fewer escalations	

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STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE TWO – SUPPORT AND DEVELOPMENT FOR LODGE MENTORS

Ref	Action	Purpose / Outcome	Success Measures	Status
II.1	Maintain up-to-date register of Lodge Mentors	Ensure visibility and continuity	Accurate register maintained	
II.2	Deliver induction briefing for new Lodge Mentors	Build confidence and role clarity	Positive feedback from new LMs	
II.3	Organise periodic Lodge Mentor meetings	Encourage peer support and consistency	Attendance and engagement levels	
II.4	Develop and maintain Provincial mentoring guidance	Provide consistent, accurate resources	Guidance used and referenced	
II.5	Encourage 3–5 year continuity of Lodge Mentors	Improve stability and effectiveness	Increased continuity of appointments	
II.6	Provide one-to-one support for Lodge Mentors where needed	Support mentors facing challenges	Issues resolved; mentor confidence improved	

STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE THREE – PROMOTING COMPREHENSIVE MEMBER LEARNING AND SUPPORT

Ref	Action	Purpose / Outcome	Success Measures	Status
III.1	Reinforce member-centred mentoring principles	Ensure mentoring is driven by individual needs	Feedback indicates improved member experience	
III.2	Promote balance of Guided and Personal Learning	Reduce confusion and dissatisfaction	Improved confidence and understanding	
III.3	Encourage use of Solomon and approved resources	Ensure accurate learning	Increased Solomon engagement	
III.4	Provide guidance on progression and pressure	Protect members from undue expectation	Reduced reports of pressured progression	
III.5	Support Lodge Mentors with Royal Arch guidance	Enable informed, well-timed decisions	Positive member feedback	

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STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE FOUR – RETENTION AND MIGRATION MANAGEMENT

Ref	Action	Purpose / Outcome	Success Measures	Status
IV.1	Promote early identification of disengagement	Prevent avoidable resignations	Earlier intervention evident	
IV.2	Clarify referral pathways to Province	Enable appropriate escalation	Clear guidance issued	
IV.3	Support constructive handling of resignations	Preserve goodwill and retrieval opportunities	Increased withdrawal of resignations	
IV.4	Implement and oversee Member Migration Process	Retain members relocating	Successful migrations completed	
IV.5	Review retention and migration trends annually	Inform Provincial priorities	Trends identified and acted upon	

REVIEW AND GOVERNANCE

Action	Responsibility	Frequency
Review Action Plan	Provincial Grand Mentor	Annually
Update priorities and timescales	Provincial Grand Mentor	As required
Report progress to Provincial Executive	Provincial Grand Mentor	At least annually

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